

Lab: Listening to What Wants to Happen

Objective

Explore planning as an embodied process of anticipation and readiness through exercises that reveal how the body prepares for action, evaluates possible futures through felt sense, and trusts emergent movement. This lab demonstrates that planning begins in the body before it reaches conscious deliberation.

Prerequisites

- A space where you can stand and move for 25 minutes
- No special equipment required
- No prior experience required

Part 1: Bodily Anticipation (5 minutes)

1. Stand at the edge of a doorway. Intend to walk through it, but do not walk yet. Hold the intention. Notice: What is your body already doing? Weight shifting? Foot angling? Gaze directing? The body is planning -- preparing the musculature, adjusting posture, predicting the sensory consequences of the upcoming movement.
2. Now intend to sit down (near a chair), but do not sit. Hold the intention. What preparatory adjustments does the body make?
3. Intend to reach for something on a high shelf (real or imagined). Do not reach. What happens in your body?

In Active Inference, planning is the evaluation of action policies by simulating their expected sensory outcomes. The body does this pre-reflectively: muscles activate, posture shifts, and autonomic tone adjusts before any conscious decision is made.

Write your response here

(For each intention, describe the preparatory changes you noticed. Where in the body does planning live?)

Part 2: Felt Evaluation of Futures (7 minutes)

Think of two possible activities for later today (e.g., going for a walk versus reading a book, cooking versus ordering food).

1. **Future A:** Close your eyes and vividly imagine doing the first activity. Do not think about it analytically -- let the body simulate it. What happens in your chest, belly, and limbs? Does the body lean toward this future or pull away?
2. **Future B:** Now imagine the second activity with the same bodily attention. What shifts?
3. **Comparison:** Which future did the body prefer? Was this different from what your analytical mind would have chosen?

This exercise demonstrates expected free energy evaluation through the body. The body simulates possible futures and generates a felt evaluation -- a somatic marker -- that guides the selection of action policies.

Write your response here

(Describe the bodily response to each imagined future. Did your body have a clear preference? How did this compare to your intellectual preference?)

Part 3: Emergent Movement (5 minutes)

Stand in the center of your space. Close your eyes. Rather than deciding what to do, ask the body: What wants to happen next?

Wait. Be patient. A movement will emerge -- perhaps a stretch, a sway, a reaching, a folding. Follow it without directing it. Let one movement flow into the next for three minutes.

This is planning without a plan. In Active Inference, the body is selecting action policies based on the expected reduction of free energy in real time, without explicit deliberation. The movement that emerges is the body's answer to the question: What will bring me closer to my predicted (preferred) state?

Write your response here

(What emerged? Describe the sequence of movements. Was there a sense of rightness or flow? Where did the body want to go?)

Part 4: Allostatic Planning (5 minutes)

Observe your body's anticipatory regulation:

1. Think about your next meal. Notice: does your mouth water? Does your belly shift? The body is already planning its digestive response.
2. Think about an upcoming challenging event (a meeting, an exam, a difficult conversation). Notice: does your heart rate change? Does your breathing shift? Muscles tense? The body is already mobilizing resources.
3. Think about rest -- lying in bed, drifting to sleep. Notice the settling, the softening.

This is allostatic planning: the body predicts future regulatory demands and begins adjusting before the event occurs. It is planning at the most fundamental biological level.

Write your response here

(Describe the bodily shifts for each imagined scenario. How does the body prepare differently for nourishment, challenge, and rest?)

Part 5: Reflection

Write your response here

(What does it mean to plan with the body rather than the mind? How might you use this embodied approach to planning in your daily life?)

Reflection Table

Planning Dimension	What I Felt	Active Inference Connection
Bodily anticipation		Pre-reflective action policy preparation
Felt future evaluation		Expected free energy as somatic marker
Emergent movement		Real-time policy selection
Allostatic planning		Predictive regulation of future states
Trusting the body		Habitual body as planning resource